

1866

FEBRUARY

Congress passes a law extending the powers of the Freedmen's Bureau to ensure that the formerly enslaved are treated fairly. President Johnson later vetoes the measure, but Congress overrides his veto.

APRIL

Congress passes a Civil Rights Act, over another presidential veto, declaring Black people to be citizens entitled to equal protection under the laws.

MAY

Six Confederate veterans form an organization called the Ku Klux Klan in Pulaski, Tennessee. Initially a social club, it will become the largest of various vigilante groups using terrorist methods to limit Black rights.

JUNE

Congress adopts the Fourteenth Amendment to the U.S. Constitution. It extends citizenship to Black people and limits the Congressional representation of any state that does not allow them to vote.

NOVEMBER

Republican supporters of the Fourteenth Amendment win a landslide victory in Congressional elections. They have radical Reconstruction plans despite the president's opposition.